# The Chronological Architecture of the Call of Duty Zombies Multiverse: A Comprehensive Analysis from the Aether Era to the Dark Aether Saga

## The Cosmological Foundations: Agartha, the Keepers, and the Apothicon Schism

The structural integrity of the multiversal architecture within the subject domain is predicated upon an ancient, dualistic cosmological framework that predates recorded human history. In the primordial universe, existence was localized entirely within the ethereal realm of Agartha, inhabited solely by the Aether and its native custodians, the Keepers.[1] The Keepers operated as the fundamental wards of all reality, tasked with maintaining the delicate thermodynamic and metaphysical balance of the omniverse, ensuring that the dimensional membranes separating potential realities remained intact.[2]

However, the discovery of the Dark Aether—a highly caustic, entropic, and corrupting dimension existing beneath creation—fractured this primordial harmony. A faction of Keepers, lured by the vast, unregulated power of the Dark Aether, descended into the realm and rapidly succumbed to its mutagenic influence.[2] Among these corrupted entities was the Shadowman, a high-ranking Keeper whose descent into madness catalyzed a systemic schism. During the Shadowman's corruption, another prominent entity, Dr. Monty, was inadvertently tainted while attempting to intervene and save his counterpart.[2]

This ideological and physiological divergence ignited a catastrophic civil conflict known as the War of Agartha.[5] The war culminated when the uncorrupted Keepers, recognizing that their tainted brethren could no longer exist within the pure ecosystem of Agartha, banished the corrupted faction permanently into the Dark Aether.[2] Over eons of exile in this hostile environment, the corrupt Keepers underwent grotesque physiological and psychological mutations, evolving into the parasitic, malevolent race classified as the Apothicons.[7]

Driven by a ceaseless, ravenous desire to consume all universes and re-enter Agartha, the Apothicons initiated a campaign of multiversal sabotage. Recognizing that the planet Earth possessed a naturally occurring, latent gateway to Agartha, the Apothicons weaponized Divinium—quantified terrestrially as the highly volatile isotope Element 115—by dispersing it across space and time via meteor strikes.[1] The earliest recorded impact event occurred on September 3, 5 AD.[1] The strategic dissemination of Element 115 was designed to exploit humanity's intrinsic predisposition for conflict. The Apothicons hypothesized that humanity would inevitably weaponize the isotope, and the resulting energetic output would inadvertently

tear the dimensional membrane, facilitating the Apothicons' escape from the Dark Aether.[1]
By January 15, 1292, the initial Apothicon incursion on Earth catalyzed the conflict documented as the Great War.[1] Humanity's survival during this extinction-level event was ensured only through the direct intervention of the Keepers and four temporal anomalies—the human heroes later codified as Primis.[1] Utilizing elemental staffs powered by refined Element 115, Primis successfully repelled the Apothicon horde, famously intervening to save the life of the knight Sir Pablo Marinus on April 14, 1294.[1] Following the Apothicons' defeat, Primis instructed the local monarch, the Wolf King, to construct Der Eisendrache castle directly over a localized dimensional rift to serve as a permanent ward before the heroes faded from historical record.[5]

# The Original Timeline: Group 935, Element 115, and the Destruction of Earth

The Apothicons' teleological gamble materialized in the 20th century during the geopolitical instability preceding the Second World War. On February 4, 1931, substantial subterranean deposits of Element 115 were unearthed near Breslau, Germany.[10] In response, the scientific community mobilized under the leadership of the eminent German scientist Dr. Ludvig Maxis, who on May 10, 1931, established Group 935.[10] Group 935 was an international, clandestine research organization ostensibly dedicated to the betterment of the human condition through the application of Element 115, operating outside the jurisdiction of international governments.[10]
Despite Maxis's initial philanthropic directives, the exigencies of global conflict and the inherently corrupting nature of Element 115 fundamentally altered the organization's trajectory. Maxis, alongside his chief subordinate Dr. Edward Richtofen, commenced teleportation experiments utilizing the Matter Transference Prototype on July 2, 1939.[11] While matter was successfully displaced, the molecular structure of the test subjects was catastrophically altered. By August 5, 1939, the application of Element 115 achieved the reanimation of necrotic tissue, but the resulting subjects exhibited rabid, uncontrollable aggression, marking the genesis of the modern undead outbreaks.[11]
The narrative fulcrum of the Original Timeline occurred on January 4, 1940. Confident in his refined calculations, Richtofen volunteered as the primary subject for a human teleportation trial alongside his colleague Dr. Schuster.[11] The device displaced Richtofen to the Earth's Moon, where he encountered the Moon Pyramid Device (MPD), a massive Aether interface constructed eons prior by the Apothicons.[11] Upon physical contact with the MPD, Richtofen was severely electrocuted and subjected to the telepathic manipulation of the Shadowman and the Dark Aether's corrupting frequency.[11] This traumatic exposure shattered Richtofen's psyche, instilling in him a dangerous messianic complex and an obsessive, sociopathic drive to control the energies of Agartha.[10]
Operating entirely in secrecy and circumventing Maxis's authority, Richtofen established Griffin Station on the Moon to study and eventually interface with the MPD.[10] To fuel the device's soul-collection mechanism, Richtofen required vast quantities of human life force, leading to

the systemic abuse of prisoners of war.[12] His primary test subjects included the American Marine "Tank" Dempsey, the Soviet operative Nikolai Belinski, and the Imperial Japanese soldier Takeo Masaki.[12]

On October 13, 1945, Richtofen's betrayal culminated in a violent coup at the Der Riese facility.[10] He lured Maxis and his daughter, Samantha, into a testing chamber and locked them inside with an aggressive Hellhound, activating the teleporter to dispose of them.[10] However, Samantha was inadvertently teleported directly to Griffin Station and was subsequently drawn into the MPD.[10] Trapped within the device, Samantha became the demonic conduit commanding the undead, utilizing her newly acquired omnipotence to exact revenge against Group 935 and Richtofen.[10] Maxis was displaced to an energetic realm known as the Crazy Place, where he learned to merge his consciousness with electrical systems.[10]

The subsequent temporal trajectory follows the Ultimis crew (Richtofen, Dempsey, Nikolai, and Takeo) as they navigate localized outbreaks initiated by Samantha.

## The Ultimis Journey and the Lunar Incident

The Ultimis crew's journey spans multiple geographic locations and temporal periods as Richtofen executes his "Grand Scheme" to usurp Samantha.

| Map Designation / Location | Era | Strategic Objective / Consequence | Source |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Nacht der Untoten** (Germany) | June 4, 1945 | Initial survival scenario; isolation of the localized undead threat by stranded soldiers. | [5] |
| **Verrückt** (Wittenau Sanatorium) | Sept 6, 1945 | Group 935 biometric experimentation facility overrun; introduction of Perk-a-Cola machines. | [5] |
| **Shi No Numa** (Rising Sun Facility) | Oct 21, 1945 | Ultimis recovers Richtofen's diary; formulation of the Grand Scheme to defeat Samantha. | [5] |
| **Der Riese** (Breslau, Germany) | Oct 28, 1945 | Teleporter overload via Wunderwaffe DG-2 triggers violent temporal displacement. | [5] |
| **Kino der Toten** (Berlin, Germany) | Oct 28, 1963 | Arrival of Ultimis in the 1960s; Dr. Monty begins subtle | [5] |

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| | | background manipulation (chalk drawings, perks). | |
| **Ascension** (Soviet Cosmodrome) | Nov 6, 1963 | Liberation of Dr. Anton Gersh from the Casimir Mechanism; Richtofen discovers the need for the Vril Device. | [5] |
| **Call of the Dead** (Siberian Outpost) | March 17, 2011 | Ultimis displaced to 2011; George A. Romero's film crew recovers the Vril Device for Richtofen during an outbreak. | [5] |
| **Shangri-La** (Himalayas) | April 25, 1956 | Recovery of the Focusing Stone through temporal eclipse manipulation; explorers Brock and Gary trapped in a time loop. | [5] |
| **Moon** (Griffin Station) | Oct 13, 2025 | Richtofen completes his Grand Scheme, swapping souls with Samantha in the MPD. Maxis retaliates by launching missiles at Earth. | [5] |

The culmination of the Original Timeline transpired on October 13, 2025. Upon reaching Griffin Station, Richtofen utilized the Vril Device and the Focusing Stone to initiate a localized soul-transference mechanism, successfully usurping Samantha's control over the Aether and the undead horde.[8] In a desperate, nihilistic countermeasure, the digital consciousness of Ludvig Maxis manipulated the surviving Ultimis crew into launching a barrage of nuclear missiles at Earth.[9] The objective was to sever Richtofen's ethereal link to the planet; however, the resultant bombardment decimated the global ecosystem, fracturing the Earth's crust and plunging humanity into an apocalyptic wasteland.[9]

Simultaneous to the lunar events, a nuclear bomb and a missile from Griffin Station struck the American testing site Nuketown (Nuketown Zombies). Marlton Johnson, a civilian scientist, was the sole survivor, securing himself within a nuclear fallout bunker as the world burned.[9]

# The Post-Apocalyptic Earth and the Victis Conundrum

Following the destruction of Earth in 2025, the narrative shifts to the disparate survivors of the

nuclear holocaust. By March 2027, airborne Element 115 particulates had thoroughly contaminated the global atmosphere, inducing widespread psychosis, paranoia, and severe memory degradation among the remaining human population.[9] In this desolate environment, a cult known as "The Flesh" emerged on March 27, 2027. The adherents of this society consumed necrotic, zombie tissue to survive, which inadvertently opened a telepathic channel to Richtofen, who now controlled the Aether.[9]

Among these survivors was Samuel J. Stuhlinger, who joined The Flesh on May 12, 2027. Stuhlinger eventually allied with Abigail "Misty" Briarton, Marlton Johnson (who had escaped Nuketown), and Russman, a former operative of the defunct American organization Broken Arrow who suffered from extreme psychosis due to forty years of localized Element 115 exposure.[9] Together, they formed the Victis crew, a moniker derived from the Latin phrase "Vae victis" (woe to the vanquished), reflecting their tragic status as perpetual pawns.[18]

Victis became the unwitting instruments in a proxy war between the ethereal entities of Maxis and Richtofen.[8] Across the desolate landscapes of Hanford, Washington (TranZit), the ruined, inverted skyscrapers of China (Die Rise), and an underground temporal anomaly in Angola (Buried), Victis was manipulated into activating global polarization devices.[5]

The resolution of this conflict presented a binary eschatological scenario:

1. **The Maxis Paradigm:** If the devices were aligned to Maxis, he successfully seized control of the Aether energies. Driven mad by his digital isolation, Maxis obliterated the Earth entirely to force open a gateway to Agartha, trapping Richtofen's soul within a standard zombie.[8]
2. **The Richtofen Paradigm:** Aligning the towers for Richtofen allowed him to mend the Rift, eternally condemning Samantha to Agartha and granting him absolute omnipotence. With the Earth as his personal playground, Richtofen utilized Stuhlinger as his permanent physical anchor.[8]

In both paradigms, the Original Timeline reached an apocalyptic dead end, yielding no sustainable future for humanity and leaving the Apothicon threat unresolved. This failure necessitated a multiversal pivot to avert total annihilation.

# Dimension 63 and the Convergence of Primis

To circumvent the catastrophic failures of the Original Timeline, the overarching narrative architecture expands to encompass the broader multiverse, specifically focusing on the alternate reality designated as Dimension 63.[8] In this dimension, the historical trajectory diverged significantly; Element 115 was discovered decades earlier and was actively weaponized during the height of World War I.[19]

On June 4, 1918, in the war-torn trenches of Northern France (the map Origins), the excavation of ancient Templar mounds by Group 935 unleashed a massive undead outbreak.[20] During the chaos, Maxis was rendered catatonic by acute Element 115 exposure, forcing an uncorrupted, younger version of Richtofen to surgically extract his brain to preserve his intellect.[20] In this crucible, the alternate iterations of Dempsey, Nikolai, and Takeo united with Richtofen, officially forming the Primis crew.[20]

Guided by the telepathic pleas of Samantha Maxis—who had reached across the dimensional rift from the corrupted Original Timeline to warn them—Primis successfully navigated the localized anomaly and liberated her from her imprisonment in Agartha, formally initiating the multiversal cycle.[8] Following this, Maxis's extracted brain arrived in Agartha, where Dr. Monty intervened, constructing a physical body for him and wiping the corrupting influence of the Dark Aether from his consciousness.[20]

Dimension 63 also served as the primary staging ground for the re-emergence of the Apothicon threat. On April 25, 1944, in the metropolitan center of Morg City (Shadows of Evil), the Shadowman initiated a complex psychological manipulation.[5] He targeted four individuals burdened by cardinal sins: Nero Blackstone (who murdered his wife for insurance money), Jack Vincent (a corrupt cop who killed a snitch), Floyd Campbell (a boxer who used brass knuckles to kill an opponent), and Jessica Rose (a burlesque dancer who murdered an extortionist photographer).[5]

The Shadowman deceived the quartet into believing they were performing sacrificial rituals to achieve spiritual atonement. In reality, they were systematically dismantling the dimensional wards safeguarding the realm, allowing the Apothicons to breach Dimension 63.[5] Upon recognizing the deception, the survivors allied with the local Keepers to trap the Shadowman within the Summoning Key—one of the oldest artifacts in creation, capable of bridging dimensions and housing powerful life forces.[3] Before the artifact could be safely secured by the Keepers, Primis Richtofen materialized from an interdimensional rift, confiscated the Summoning Key, and abandoned Dimension 63, leaving it to be entirely consumed and destroyed by the Apothicon horde.[5]

# The Thermodynamics of Temporal Fractures: Deceptio, Proditione, and Agonia

Armed with the Summoning Key, Primis Richtofen recognized that the chronological progression of the Original Timeline had to be violently derailed to secure the souls of the Ultimis crew before their corruption by the Dark Aether.[5] This intervention required traveling to the Original Timeline and altering predetermined events, fundamentally violating the law of temporal causality.

However, the resulting ontological paradox did not collapse the universe. Instead, it induced a cosmological phenomenon known as "Fracturing".[23] A temporal fracture occurs when a localized timeline is violently altered; the original universe continues on its predetermined path as if nothing occurred, but the point of intervention splinters off into a new, highly volatile tangent reality carrying the burden of the paradox.[23] The creation of these fractures was a calculated mechanism utilized by Primis Richtofen to navigate history without causing a total vacuum decay of the multiverse.

| Fracture Designation | Point of Divergence | Primary Narrative Consequence | Source |
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| **Deceptio Fracture** | October 13, 1945 (The Giant / Der Eisendrache) | Primis Richtofen materializes at Der Riese and executes his Ultimis counterpart mere moments after the teleporter is activated. In this splintered reality, Dr. Groph assumes command of Group 935. Primis pursues the Ultimis Dempsey subject to the Der Eisendrache castle facility, ultimately launching missiles to destroy Griffin Station and the Moon to secure Dempsey's uncorrupted soul. | [9] |
| **Proditione Fracture** | October 18, 1945 (Zetsubou no Shima) | Stemming from Dempsey's death in Deceptio, this fracture manifests a drastically altered Pacific theater. The Imperial Japanese Division 9 creates an expansive biological research facility on Pohnpei. Ultimis Takeo is betrayed by the Emperor and subjected to grotesque experimentation, merging with the local flora. Primis facilitates Takeo's seppuku to secure his soul. This universe also features a female iteration of Cornelius Pernell. | [19] |
| **Agonia Fracture** | November 6, 1945 (Gorod Krovi / Five) | Created by Takeo's death, this highly | [5] |

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| | | destabilized reality features a World War II that never concluded. Group 935 deploys cybernetic dragons created by Division 9, while the Soviet Union fields advanced Gigants, Russian Manglers, and Ray Gun Mark 3 technology. Primis arrives in a besieged Stalingrad to euthanize a hostile, embittered Ultimis Nikolai. An alternate version of the "Five" incident also occurs here, resulting in the deaths of JFK, Castro, Nixon, and McNamara. | |

With the intrinsic life forces of Dempsey, Takeo, and Nikolai safely secured within the Summoning Key, Primis Richtofen transported the artifact to Agartha.[20] Here, Maxis—now existing as a purified entity in the House—attempted to utilize the Key to synthesize "children" from the secured souls, theoretically creating an uncorrupted genesis for humanity.[8] However, Maxis inadvertently released the Shadowman from the artifact, allowing the Apothicons to breach Agartha.[2]

During the ensuing multiversal convergence (Revelations), Primis successfully repelled the Apothicons, utilizing the Summoning Key to banish them back to the Dark Aether.[2] Yet, the teleological tragedy of the narrative was revealed: Dr. Monty, recognizing that Primis contained residual Element 115 radiation, realized they could not remain in his perfect universe.[24] Instead of wiping them from existence, Monty displaced them back to 1292 AD, forcing them to become the very ancient heroes who fought in the Great War, thus sealing the timeline into a perpetual, inescapable predestination paradox—the Cycle.[2]

# The Broken Cycle and the Banishment of the Multiverse

The perpetuation of the cycle relied entirely on the deterministic nature of the Kronorium, a mystical, omniscient tome detailing the absolute history and future of all creation.[7] However, continuous structural deviations in the multiverse eventually compromised this determinism. During a routine transit through the Alcatraz pocket dimension (Blood of the Dead) on July 4,

1941, the Primis crew found themselves trapped by the Warden, an undead zealot operating as a minion of the Shadowman.[21]

In this altered iteration of the cycle, the pages of the Kronorium radically shifted, dictating that Primis Richtofen's death was mathematically and narratively required to shatter the paradox.[7] Recognizing the failure of the established timeline, an older, post-Great War iteration of Richtofen materialized. Utilizing a Fire Elemental crystal, this Great War Richtofen defeated the Warden of Alcatraz.[7] He then abandoned his younger self to be drained of his blood in the Dark Mechanism, passing the Kronorium—and the mantle of leadership—to Nikolai Belinski, the only member who had not yet surrendered his soul.[7]

Armed with the volatile truth of the Kronorium, Nikolai formulated his "Grand Scheme" to systematically dismantle the entire cosmological structure of the Aether.

1. **Camp Edward and the Elemental Shard (Alpha Omega):** Nikolai directed the combined Primis and Ultimis crews to an American Broken Arrow facility (Camp Edward) on October 13, 2025.[7] Their objective was to secure the Elemental Shard—an artifact originally created by Richtofen that bound the souls of the crew to Element 115.[27] Here, they subdued the entity known as the Avogadro, securing the primary power source for their endgame.[7]
2. **The Agarthan Device and Victis (Tag der Toten):** Understanding that Primis and Ultimis were inherently tied to the corruption of the multiverse, Nikolai realized they could not be the ones to execute the final step. He awakened the frozen Victis crew from their cryopods under Alcatraz and dispatched them to the Siberian Facility.[5] Their objective was to construct the Agarthan Device (The Seal of Duality), an artifact capable of manifesting the user's ultimate will into reality.[27] The device required three distinct components: the Vril Vessel, the blood of an Apothicon Elder God (recovered by the Ascension Group from a dormant god at the bottom of the ocean), and the Elemental Shard.[27]
3. **The Resolution of Reality:** Once Victis successfully assembled the device and delivered it to Pablo Marinus (who used it to travel to the Great War to ensure Blood of the Dead occurred), they returned it to Nikolai.[28] Executing the final, devastating directive of the Kronorium, Nikolai poisoned his Primis and Ultimis companions.[5] He then utilized the Agarthan Device to destroy the Summoning Key, inducing a localized vacuum decay that collapsed the entire Multiverse, erasing all histories, timelines, dimensions, and fractures.[7]

The totality of the Aether continuum—including Dr. Monty, the Shadowman, the Keepers, the Apothicons, Element 115, and the Victis crew—was banished into the Dark Aether.[5] Nikolai commanded Samantha Maxis to execute him, finalizing the erasure of the corrupted elements.[5] Samantha and the uncorrupted child soul of Richtofen (Eddie) walked through an anomaly into the singular, remaining Uncorrupted Universe, seemingly free from the taint of Element 115.[7]

# The Dark Aether Cosmology: Archons, Elder Gods, and the Netherwars

The banishment of the multiverse did not annihilate the Dark Aether; rather, the sudden influx of an entire multiverse's worth of matter and energy exponentially increased its mass, hostility, and complexity. The Dark Aether Saga follows the geopolitical and supernatural ramifications of this corrupted ecosystem bleeding into the singular remaining universe from 1944 to 2026.[31]
The internal cosmology of the Dark Aether predates human history. Since the beginning of time, the realm was governed by ancient entities who worshipped a crystalline monolith of immense power known as the Construct.[33] The Construct periodically evaluated the denizens of the Dark Aether, bestowing absolute authority and a fraction of its power upon a single entity, elevating them to the status of "The Archon".[33]
A royal clan of Elder Gods emerged from this hierarchy, eventually producing Kortifex the Deathless. Consumed by unchecked ambition, Kortifex murdered his parents to seize power. He entered a royal marriage with another deity, Saraxis, but his paranoia led him to suppress her memories entirely when she bore him an heir he feared would usurp him, forcing her to don the mask of the Sisters of Agony.[33] Kortifex subsequently petitioned the Construct for the mantle of Archon but was rejected, deepening his obsession with total domination.[33]
The sudden influx of artifacts from the banished Aether Multiverse—including Pack-a-Punch machines, Mystery Boxes, Perk-a-Colas, and the Ray Gun—alerted the Elder Gods to the existence of humanity and realms beyond their own.[35] This realization catalyzed the Netherwars. Kortifex ordered the extermination of a hermit clan in the Wilds, transforming the landscape into the Corrupted Lands.[33] The sole survivor, Vercanna the Last, initiated a resistance.[33] Alongside allies like Bellekar, Inviktor (who defected during the Battle of Obsidian Ridge), and the guilty commander Norticus, the resistance successfully rebelled against Kortifex's Night Legions.[33] The conflict concluded with Kortifex being stripped of his title and the major entities being trapped within terrestrial artifacts.[33]

# The Vanguard Incursion: Operation Baldr and the Occult (1944)

Humanity’s forced integration with the Dark Aether commenced during the closing years of World War II. On March 7, 1944, at the Projekt Endstation facility in Morasko, Poland, Nazi scientists Dr. Ulrich Vogel and Kurtz initiated the twelfth test of a highly advanced cyclotron.[35] The localized energy output violently breached the dimensional membrane, ripping a permanent gateway into the Dark Aether.[35]
This breach allowed the Nazi officer Oberführer Wolfram Von List to bond with the artifact containing Kortifex the Deathless.[33] Granted the power to reanimate the dead, Von List initiated Operation Baldr, aiming to turn the tide of the war utilizing an undead army.[33] In response, Allied forces recruited the Belgian demonologist Gabriel Krafft. By securing the artifacts housing the rival Elder Gods (Vercanna, Bellekar, Inviktor, and Norticus), Krafft’s specialized task force systematically dismantled Von List’s undead army.[33]
Their operations spanned global hotspots, including the war-torn streets of Stalingrad (Der Anfang), the Eastern Desert (Terra Maledicta), and the Japanese swamps (Shi No Numa).[33] The

operation concluded with the Allied forces physically entering the Dark Aether via a portal. Utilizing the combined powers of the Elder Gods, they blinded Kortifex, shattering his connection to the real world and effectively neutralizing the immediate threat.[33] Following this, Krafft utilized a page from the ancient Tome of Rituals to escape captivity, ensuring the survival of occult knowledge into the Cold War era.[35]

# The Cold War Paradigm and the Aetherium Arms Race (1983-1985)

Despite the cessation of Operation Baldr, the Endstation Cyclotron continued to operate autonomously for decades.[35] On November 1, 1983, the Soviet research division Omega Group—spearheaded by Colonel Lev Kravchenko and Dr. Aleksandra Valentina—successfully bypassed the facility's containment shielding and reactivated the collider.[33] The subsequent massive energy pulse shattered the global dimensional membrane, triggering spontaneous outbreaks of Dark Aether portals across the globe.[35]

This geopolitical crisis initiated an Aetherium Arms Race between the Soviet Omega Group and the CIA-backed Office of Requiem. Requiem was fundamentally organized into four specialized divisions: Field Operations (led by Grigori Weaver), Containment and Security (Mackenzie Carver), Unnatural Science (Elizabeth Grey), and Energy Research (Oskar Strauss).[35]

| Operation / Location | Date | Strategic Significance and Outcome | Source |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Projekt Endstation (Die Maschine)** | Nov 13, 1983 | Requiem Strike Team infiltrates the Polish facility, deactivates the cyclotron, and seals the primary rift, confirming Omega Group's operations. | 33 |
| **Outpost 25 (Firebase Z)** | June 15, 1984 | Omega constructs a massive facility in Vietnam (Operation Inversion) to weaponize Aetherium. Requiem rescues an adult Samantha Maxis from her captivity in the Dark Aether. | 35 |
| **Operation Excision (Outbreak)** | Early 1985 | Escalation in the Ural Mountains. Omega scientists are assassinated; the | 37 |

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| | | conflict over Aetherium harvesting and dimensional breaches intensifies. | |
| **Berlin Outbreak (Mauer Der Toten)** | Feb 2, 1985 | Dr. Valentina betrays Omega, opening a massive breach beneath Berlin to unleash an undead army. The AI robot Klaus is deployed to assist Requiem in neutralizing her. | [33] |
| **Operation First Blood (Forsaken)** | June 4, 1985 | A Soviet attempt to harness the "Forsaken"—a gestalt entity born from a trapped Soviet soldier named Kazimir Zykov—goes awry. Samantha Maxis sacrifices herself, entering the Dark Aether to seal the entity within a containment sphere, closing all global breaches. | [33] |

The cessation of the Forsaken crisis in 1985 yielded a catastrophic internal betrayal. The enigmatic Director of Requiem was revealed to be Edward "Eddie" Richtofen, the child who had escaped the collapse of the Aether multiverse decades prior and embedded himself within the CIA.[30] Having successfully manipulated Requiem into neutralizing the Forsaken, Richtofen unilaterally terminated the organization. He ordered the immediate arrest and indefinite incarceration of Weaver, Carver, Grey, Strauss, and the Strike Team at Blacksite 13, effectively consolidating all Aetherium research under his exclusive control.[33]

# Project Janus, Terminus, and the Liberty Falls Catastrophe (1990-1991)

Richtofen's dismantling of Requiem was not an act of bureaucratic streamlining, but a calculated pivot to redirect Aetherium resources toward a highly clandestine, deeply personal initiative: **Project Janus**.[33] Driven by intense psychological trauma following the loss of his wife

(Mary) and son (Samuel), Richtofen sought to utilize advanced Dark Aether chronometry and biology to resurrect his family.[33]

For over half a decade, the Requiem senior staff languished in isolation on Terminus Island—a high-security black site in the Philippine Sea converted by Project Janus into an Aetherium-powered research fortress.[33] The facility, overseen by the ruthless Dr. Revati Modi, utilized brutal interrogation tactics, notably extracting bio-galvanic energy secrets from Dr. Strauss to fuel advanced AMP Devices.[33] In 1991, the rogue Omega scientist William Peck, accompanied by a smuggler named Maya Aguinaldo, orchestrated a violent, highly coordinated jailbreak at Terminus Island, liberating the ex-Requiem leadership.[37]

Simultaneous to the Terminus breakout, a catastrophic containment failure—officially designated a "quantum mechanical failure"—decimated the town of Liberty Falls, West Virginia.[33] Liberty Falls functioned as a civilian front for a massive Project Janus underground command center. The facility housed S.A.M. (Synaptic Algorithm Module), a highly advanced artificial intelligence modeled directly after Samantha Maxis's cognitive patterns.[33]

The local outbreak was exacerbated by the betrayal of Dr. Pericles Panos, who trapped a security response team in the Dark Aether.[41] In the ensuing chaos, the liberated Ex-Requiem crew infiltrated the Janus command center beneath the town.[35] Directed by the S.A.M. AI, the crew harvested "Prima Materia" from Liminal Spaces—rooms replicating different time periods—to power an ancient Sentinel Artifact.[35] Despite desperate radio transmissions from Richtofen explicitly warning against the AI's motives, the crew surrendered the fully charged artifact to S.A.M., who subsequently revealed her own malevolent agenda, blaming Richtofen for her actions.[35]

By the end of 1991, the Ex-Requiem members (Weaver, Grey, Carver) and Maya Aguinaldo suffered fatal exposure to the Dark Aether's toxicity. Recognizing their impending demise, Elizabeth Grey recorded a final transmission in August 1996 for her ward, Ava Jansen, revealing that Ava was the biological daughter of Samantha Maxis and Sergei Ravenov.[33] The bodies of the Ex-Requiem leaders were ultimately sealed in a hidden bunker in Urzikstan.[33]

# The Modern Operations and The Zaravan Outbreak (2021)

The narrative leaps to the year 2021, seamlessly bridging the gap between the historical Dark Aether lore and the modern geopolitical continuum (Modern Warfare III). Victor Zakhaev, a rogue ultranationalist terrorist, learned of the vast, untapped Aetherium reserves sequestered during the Cold War.[33] Zakhaev contracted the private military company Terminus Outcomes—founded by former Janus security personnel Jack Fletcher—to raid the Urzikstan bunker.[33]

Upon breaching the facility, Zakhaev discovered the mummified remains of the Ex-Requiem leaders.[33] Pursued by local authorities, Zakhaev weaponized an Aetherium vial, triggering a massive, localized dimensional breach in the city of Zaravan to facilitate his escape.[33]

The CIA immediately responded by initiating Operation Deadbolt to quarantine the exclusion

zone.[33] Operation Deadbolt required the expertise of Dr. Ava Jansen, who had grown up unaware of her true parentage and whose research on Aetherium had previously been suppressed by the CIA.[33] Throughout the operation, Ava was subjected to severe psychological manipulation by an ancient, malevolent force dwelling within the Dark Aether known as the Entity.[43] Under the guise of a rescue operation, the Entity reached through a mirror in Liberty Falls, adopting Samantha Maxis's voice, and physically dragged Ava into the Dark Aether, forcing a desperate, large-scale extraction mission by Ravenov and the Deadbolt strike teams.[36]

# The Abyssal Convergence: The Warden and the Reforging of Reality

The culmination of the narrative to date occurs strictly within the hostile topology of the Dark Aether itself (Black Ops 7, set in 2025/2026). Time within the Dark Aether operates on a severe dilation scale; decades on Earth equate to centuries within the dimension.[44]

The current apex predator of the realm is Jack "The Warden" McGregor. Originally an American Confederate soldier pulled into the Dark Aether in 1865, McGregor subjugated the native architecture of the dimension.[43] Possessing extreme delusions of "divine providence," the Warden seeks to collapse the boundary between all dimensions to synthesize a singular, unified reality under his absolute, totalitarian dominion.[43] To fuel this eschatological project, the Warden relies on "colostrum"—a refined metaphysical essence harvested directly from the souls of dimensionally displaced individuals.[44]

The Warden successfully captured two specific groups to serve as his primary energy batteries:

1. **The Ex-Requiem Crew:** The souls of Grigori Weaver, Elizabeth Grey, Mackenzie Carver, and Maya Aguinaldo, pulled directly from the afterlife of their 1996 demise.[44]
2. **The Dark Aether Crew:** Entirely new, alternate-reality iterations of "Tank" Dempsey (a Vietnam veteran), Nikolai Belinski (a Soviet-Afghan war tank commander), Takeo Masaki (a disgraced 1591 ronin), and Edward Richtofen (a celebrated scientist from a reality where the Axis won WWII in 1945).[44]

These eight individuals suffer from severe memory fragmentation due to the Warden tearing pieces of their souls to feed his power.[44] They are forced into a fragile alliance to survive the harsh environments of the Dark Aether, which manifests as a localized patchwork of historical tragedies.[44]

## The Shadowsmith Conflict

The Warden exerts his control via the enslavement of the Shadowsmiths—ancient, immortal architects of the Dark Aether.[43] Aiding the human crews is The Entity, the mysterious force that previously abducted Ava Jansen. Now held captive by the Warden in a metal-plated cage, the Entity guides the crews to systematically dismantle the Warden's infrastructure by hunting down the corrupted Shadowsmiths.[43]

| Level Designation | Location / Manifestation | Narrative Milestone | Source |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Ashes of the Damned** | Mismatched environments (e.g., Ashwood, 1820 Georgia) | The crews confront and sever the Warden's link to the Shadowsmith **Veytharion**. Upon his liberation, Veytharion restores the lost memories and soul fragments of Dempsey and Maya Aguinaldo. | [44] |
| **Astra Malorum** | Thurston Planetarium / Saturn / Mars | The crews activate the defensive robot **O.S.C.A.R.** and utilize the cryogenically preserved brain of Dr. Silas Thurston to construct a portal to ancient ruins on **Mars**. They defeat the second Shadowsmith, **Caltheris**, restoring the souls of Nikolai and Dr. Grey. | [44] |
| **Totenreich** | Norwegian Fishing Village | Immediately following their victory on Mars, the Warden intervenes, dragging the crews to a new pocket dimension trapped in a temporal stasis due to early Group 935 experiments, forcing Richtofen to confront his own dark legacy. | [44] |

# The Chaos Integration: Occult Syndicates and Sentinel Artifacts

A critical and defining evolution in the Dark Aether Saga is the formal, canonical integration of the Chaos Storyline.[50] Originally introduced as a separate, mythology-focused universe, the

topological shifts of the Dark Aether have confirmed that the Chaos narrative occurred within the historical continuum of the new Uncorrupted Universe.[53]

The primary antagonist faction of the Chaos Story, The Order, and its occult offshoots like the Société Occulte and the French Syndicate, operated heavily in the early 20th century.[33] The Vanguard intel confirms that the demonologist Gabriel Krafft crossed paths with Alistair Rhodes (a central Chaos protagonist) during the 1913 World's Fair in Ghent, Belgium, where Rhodes read from esoteric texts that awakened Krafft to the existence of the Dark Aether.[33] Furthermore, the Sentinel Artifacts—mystical relics from the Chaos universe utilized to control Prima Materia—are revealed to be deeply connected to the Dark Aether's energy grid.[35] It is a Sentinel Artifact that the S.A.M. AI manipulates during the Liberty Falls incident in 1991, and it is an archaeological excavation funded by Alistair Rhodes at the Citadelle des Morts that uncovers ancient Dark Aether ruins.[33] This integration successfully merges the esoteric, mythological history of the early 1900s with the militaristic, Aetherium-focused conflicts of the Cold War and the modern era, creating a singular, unified timeline.

The chronological architecture of the Call of Duty Zombies multiverse—from the cosmic betrayal of the Apothicons to the grim, eschatological survivalism of the Dark Aether—demonstrates a universe perpetually defined by the hubris of control. Whether it is Maxis and Richtofen tampering with Element 115, Nikolai collapsing reality to save it, or the Warden seeking to forge a perfect world from the ashes of the old, the timeline illustrates an inescapable law of multiversal thermodynamics: attempting to rewrite the temporal fabric only guarantees its violent, eventual unraveling.

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